

STELLAR ASTROPHYSICS

Astronomy 310, Fall 2026

Department of Astronomy, University of Wisconsin–Madison

Course Information

Course Description: Properties of normal and peculiar stars as found from an analysis of the radiation they emit; introduction to radiation transfer. Theory of stellar atmospheres, interiors, and evolution.

Stars are the building blocks of the Universe. They drive the energetic and chemical evolution of galaxies, and the elements heavier than helium that make up the world around us were forged inside them. This course develops the physics of stars in the order an astronomer encounters them: first what we observe, then how we model the light that reaches us, and finally what is happening inside. We begin with stellar observations (distances, magnitudes, colors, spectra, binaries, the Hertzsprung–Russell diagram) and the parameters they yield. We then study stellar atmospheres, where radiation and matter interact to produce the spectra we measure: the radiative transfer equation, opacity sources, the Eddington gray-atmosphere approximation, and the formation of spectral lines. With those observational and atmospheric foundations in place, we turn to stellar interiors and the equations of stellar structure: hydrostatic equilibrium, the equation of state including electron degeneracy, energy transport by radiation and convection, and nuclear energy generation from the pp chain through advanced burning. We close with a more compact treatment of stellar evolution, surveying the main sequence, post-main-sequence phases, stellar remnants (white dwarfs, neutron stars, black holes), supernovae, and close-binary evolution.

Credits: 3 (Carnegie Unit)

Credit Hour Explanation: This class meets for two, 75-minute class periods each week. For each credit earned, students should expect to spend approximately two hours per week outside of class completing readings, assignments, studying, and other course activities. Thus, for this 3-credit course, students should anticipate about 6 hours of out-of-class work per week, in addition to scheduled class meetings.

Requisites: MATH 222 and (PHYSICS 205, 241, or 249, or concurrent enrollment).

Course Designations/Attributes:

- Breadth: Physical Science. Counts toward the Natural Science requirement.
- Level: Intermediate
- L&S Credit: Counts as Liberal Arts and Science credit in L&S
- Repeatable for Credit: No

Course Learning Outcomes

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

1. Describe the properties of stars and explain how these properties are deduced from the radiation that they emit.
2. Define the basic principles of radiative transfer and apply these principles to interpreting the atmospheres of stars.
3. Apply basic physical principles and mathematical techniques learned in prerequisite classes to understand the structure, evolution, and ultimate fates of stars.
4. Demonstrate thinking like a scientist, applying heuristics such as dimensional analysis and order-of-magnitude estimation to obtain quick insights into unfamiliar systems.
5. Communicate scientific concepts and results clearly, using a combination of writing and visual representations with bibliographic references as appropriate.
6. Access, read, and critically evaluate existing scientific literature and information repositories relating to stellar astrophysics.

Meeting & Instructor Information

Lecture:	Mon & Wed 2:30–3:45 PM	Location:	Sterling Hall, Room 1333
Professor:	Melinda Soares-Furtado	Email:	mmsoares@wisc.edu
		Office:	Chamberlin Hall, Room 6275
		Office Hours:	Mon 9:00–10:00 AM; Wed 4:00–5:30 PM

Materials

Link to Canvas Site: This course will be administered through Canvas, with additional course information available on the course website: <https://msoaresfurtado.com/Courses.html>. Course readings and assignment information will be posted there, while all assignments should be submitted via file upload on the Canvas site.

Other Digital Instructional Tools: Piazza will be the primary form of communication for this course.

Required Textbook:

- o Pinsonneault, M.H., and Ryden, B.S. *Stellar Structure and Evolution* (Cambridge University Press, 2023; ISBN 978-1-009-19384-3). [\[link\]](#)

Chapter readings are listed in the course outline at the end of this syllabus.

Software: Calculating realistic stellar structure and evolution models requires a numerical code. For one of the homework assignments we will use (Modules for Experiments in Stellar Astrophysics) MESA Web, an online interface to the MESA code that runs in your browser and requires no installation. MESA Web is freely available at <https://mesastar.org/>. Full instructions on how to use the interface for our problem sets will be provided in class.

Coursework & Grading

Grades are based on points earned from homework, weekly online reflection questions, and one final exam. Seven problem sets are assigned across the semester. Problem sets and reflection questions are submitted through Canvas. Grades are not curved, though AB/BC designations apply near boundaries. Attendance is not graded directly, but the weekly reflection questions described below serve as the class-participation component of the grade.

Grading Policy:

Homework Sets	65%
Final Exam	25%
Reflection Questions	10%

Grading Distribution:

A	90–100%
B	80–90%
C	70–80%
D	60–70%
F	<60%

Problem Sets: Problem sets should be submitted on Canvas. One of the sets includes a MESA Web computational component. Not every problem will be graded in detail: each set will have one or more “anchor” problems graded carefully for correctness and physical reasoning, with the remaining problems graded for completion and engagement. Anchor problems are not identified in advance.

Collaboration on problem-set strategy is welcome and encouraged: talking through approaches with classmates, comparing answers, and helping each other find errors are all normal and beneficial parts of doing physics. However, the final written work you submit must be your own, in your own words, and reflect your own understanding. If you collaborated with classmates on a problem, list their names at the top of the submission; this is not penalized and is good scholarly practice. Late problem sets lose 10% per 24 hours late, up to 72 hours; beyond that, late work is accepted only with a documented excuse. Each student is allowed one no-questions-asked 48-hour extension per semester, requested by email before the deadline.

Reflection Questions: Each week you will complete a short set of online reflection questions on Canvas, due Sundays at 11:59 PM. The prompts may ask you to summarize the week's central physical idea in your own words, identify which concept or derivation you found most challenging, or connect the week's material to topics covered earlier in the semester or to a current question in stellar astrophysics. Reflections are short (a few sentences per prompt is sufficient) and are graded on completion and engagement rather than correctness. Their purpose is to support active learning and to give the instructor ongoing feedback on what is and is not landing in lecture.

Exams: There will be one final, held in-person. The exam will be one hour in duration and is open book: you may bring either required textbook (or a printout of relevant chapters), the recommended reference, your own handwritten or typed notes, and graded problem sets. Cell phones and laptops are prohibited; bring your own non-networked calculator. Exam questions will emphasize physical reasoning rather than memorized facts, so having reference material on hand will be useful but is not a substitute for understanding the material.

Note on the Final Exam: The registrar has scheduled our final exam for Wednesday, December 16, 7:45–9:45 AM. Because that is a very early hour, students are offered the option to take the final exam in class on the last day of class instead (Wednesday, December 9, 2:30–3:30 PM). You may choose either slot. Please declare your preference no later than the start of the last week of class (Monday, December 7) by submitting the preference form on Canvas. The final exam is one hour in length regardless of which slot you choose.

Exam Dates:
Final Exam, Option 1 (in class) Dec 9, 2026 (2:30–3:30 PM)
Final Exam, Option 2 (registrar slot) Dec 16, 2026 (7:45–8:45 AM)

Academic Policies & Statements

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities: Faculty and students share responsibility in the accommodation process. Students are expected to inform faculty of their need for instructional accommodations by the end of the third week of the semester, or as soon as possible after a disability has been incurred or recognized. I can work directly with you or in coordination with the McBurney Center to provide reasonable instructional and course-related accommodations. Disability information, including instructional accommodations as part of a student's educational record, is confidential and protected under FERPA. <http://mcburney.wisc.edu/facstaffother/faculty/syllabus.php>

Academic Honesty: I expect you to do your own work, represent your ideas accurately, and give credit to others when you use their words or research. Discussing concepts and working through problems with classmates is encouraged, but please identify your collaborators, and make sure that anything you submit reflects your own understanding and writing. Use of online answer banks (e.g., Chegg or CourseHero) is not permitted. AI tools such as ChatGPT or Claude can sometimes be useful for exploring ideas or checking an explanation, but they should not replace your own reasoning. I encourage you to complete assignments without relying on an LLM to generate your answers. If you do use an AI tool, clearly state which tool you used and how you used it. Your submitted work must still reflect your own understanding and writing. Undisclosed AI-generated work or other academic dishonesty will result in a grade of zero on that assignment, and applicable University policies will be followed (conduct.students.wisc.edu). Please reach out to me if you are ever unsure about what is acceptable.

Course Schedule

Lecture slides and notes are posted on the [course website](#) after each class (although sometimes I will post them before class). Weekly reflection questions are due Sundays at 11:59 PM on Canvas.

Wk	Dates	Topic	Reading	Due
Part I — Observations				
1	Sep 2	Properties of stars: course overview, observing the Sun, observed properties of stars	Ch 1.1–1.2	Reflection: Sep 6
2	Sep 9	Observing the Sun and observed properties of stars (continued)	Ch 1.1–1.2	HW 1: Sep 11 Reflection: Sep 13
3	Sep 14, 16	Correlations among stellar properties; star clusters; the H–R diagram	Ch 1.3–1.4	Reflection: Sep 20
Part II — Stellar Structure				
4	Sep 21, 23	Equations of stellar structure: mass conservation, hydrostatic and thermal equilibrium, energy transport	Ch 2.1–2.4	HW 2: Sep 25 Reflection: Sep 27
5	Sep 28, 30	Equations of state: central pressure, quantum statistics, ideal-gas pressure	Ch 3.1–3.3	Reflection: Oct 4
6	Oct 5, 7	Electron degeneracy, radiation pressure, opacity	Ch 3.4–3.5; 4.1	HW 3: Oct 9 Reflection: Oct 11
7	Oct 12, 14	Energy transport: convection, mixing-length theory, convective overshoot	Ch 4.2–4.4	Reflection: Oct 18
8	Oct 19, 21	Stars as fusion reactors: quantum tunneling, energy generation, the pp chain	Ch 5.1–5.3	HW 4: Oct 23 Reflection: Oct 25
9	Oct 26, 28	CNO cycle and triple-alpha process; main-sequence internal structure and polytropes	Ch 5.4–5.5; 6.1–6.2	Reflection: Nov 1
10	Nov 2, 4	Main-sequence stars: homology, solar models, zero-age main-sequence models	Ch 6.3–6.5	HW 5: Nov 6 Reflection: Nov 8
Part III — Stellar Evolution				
11	Nov 9, 11	Star formation and pre-main-sequence evolution: collapse, protostars, and contraction toward the main sequence (one-week overview)	Ch 7.1–7.6	Reflection: Nov 15
12	Nov 16, 18	Evolved stars: building a helium core, the Schönberg–Chandrasekhar limit, shell hydrogen burning and red giants	Ch 8.1–8.3	HW 6 (MESA Web): Nov 20 Reflection: Nov 22
13	Nov 23, 25	Helium ignition and core helium burning, the asymptotic giant branch, s-process, superwinds, planetary nebulae (Thanksgiving recess Nov 26–29)	Ch 8.4–8.7	
14	Nov 30, Dec 2	Ex-stars: white dwarfs, neutron stars and black holes, core-collapse supernovae, r-process	Ch 9.1–9.4	HW 7: Dec 4
15	Dec 7, 9	Course synthesis and review — Final Exam (in-class option), Dec 9	Review	